APPALLING RAILWAY DISASTER.

THE "FLYING SCOTSMAN" IN COLLISION AT THIRSK.

DESTRUCTION OF THE TRAIN BY FIRE.

NINE PASSENGERS AND A GUARD KILLED.

HEARTRENDING SCENES.

LIST OF THE DEAD AND INJURED.

A terrible railway accident, which possesses some features of interest not often recalled in the annals of railway disaster, happened yesterday morning on the North-Eastern Railway between Thirsk and Northallerton. About half-past four o'clock in the morning the Flying Scotchman, rushing through York-shire at its ordinary pace, ran into a goods train, which was also proceeding southwards. The front part of the passenger train was wrecked, and to crown the calamity it caught fire. Ten persons are known to have lost their lives, and the bodies of two of them, besides being crushed to pieces by the collision, were burnt to cinders in the flames. But appalling as the result is, the consequences of the catastrophe are made less terrible by the escapes from harm, which can only be regarded as marvellous, considering all the circumstances. On Tuesday night the East Coast express from Scotland came south, as it not infrequently does, in two sections. The first section escaped the fatal spot without obstruction, but the second came to fearful grief. The train is timed to leave Edinburgh at 10.20, but it was later than usual in quitting the Waverley Station. The night was foggy generally over the north of England, but the progress of the train does not seem on that account to have been much impeded. After the first section of the train had passed a heavily-laden mineral train from Middlesbrough to Starbeck came along the main line, and stopped just at Manor House Cabin. After a short wait it was allowed to proceed. It had just started when the second portion of the Scotch express came flying along and dashed into its rear. The shock to the passenger train was so tremendous, from the position of the signals that the way was not clear, and the speed of the train was accordingly express rate. Driver and fireman were thrown out into a field. The latter, wonderful to relate, escaped comparatively unhurt, but his companion had his thigh broken. The guard in the rear van of the goods train was killed. The scene of the catastrophe is nearly three miles north of Thirsk Station, just before the train enters a little plantation of firs. Open fields stretch on each side of the line, and the nearest habitations are the group of whitewashed houses which constitute the Manor House Farm, with its outbuildings. The collisions came like a crash of thunder. In an instant the engine and the front carriages were a chaotic heap of splintered woodwork and broken metal, with, unfortunately, men and women piled up in the mass with the life crushed out of them. It may be safe to assume that all the victims, with two exceptions—that of a child who had died in her mother's arms on the way to Thirsk, and a male adult passenger—were spared all the horrors of a lingering death.

THE TRAIN ON FIRE.

The doctors present agree in the belief that no moments of poignant consciousness could have been the unhappy lot of most of those who met their death; for the shock was too appalling, and their crushed corpses told too plainly that they had been killed outright. All the passengers were plunged in sudden darkness. The train was at its pace, which would cut when the shock came, and it is probable that the gas escaped without ignition or explosion. Very soon the scattered fires of the furnaces set the wreck ablaze, and the flames acted as a beacon to light up the ghastly scene that just the pass of the startled passengers who were lucky enough to escape harm. This rude awakening in the middle of the night from the dreary wakefulness or the sound sleep incident of a long railway journey was an experience to be ever afterwards remembered, but only with a shudder. The memory was bitterly chill, too, for amongst the some accounts, foggy, although the Marquis of Tweeddale, who was one of the passengers, describes the atmosphere as clear. One extraordinary result of the collision cannot have any parallel among all the miracles of lucky escape in the history of railway disasters. The Pullman car, which was arrayed from the engine by a carriage of third-class compartments and the guard's van, not only stood the shock of collision without being smashed to pieces, but the body of it bounded from its wheels, and landed some yards in front of the engine. And yet none of the passengers in the car were either killed or seriously injured. They were all asleep at the time, and though violently shaken and thrown about the compartment, they were able afterwards to proceed upon their journey. The front part of the car, containing the lavatory, was smashed and torn away, and the whole structure was dislocated and knocked out of shape. The third-class carriage between the Pullman and the van was smashed to matchwood, and its occupants must have been killed instantaneously. Fortunately there was no one in the front guard's van. This was a providential escape for the guard, who at Darlington left the front van and went into the middle van. There was a composite carriage behind the Pullman car, into which the latter telescoped. All this damage was accomplished in flight time, for the collision is realized. It is actually said that the train was not only maintaining the magnificent speed which has gained for the Flying Scotchman a world-wide fame, but was rushing on in a clearer atmosphere at an extra pace, so as to make up for the half-hour lost in the fog between Berwick and Northallerton. The terrific jolt flung the passengers in the hindmost carriages from their seats; luggage came crashing down from the racks, and rattled with falling glass from the windows; and shrieks of alarm rose from the passengers. Some of those in the front carriages who escaped found themselves pinned in and unable to move; but with the aid of the more fortunate passengers they extricated themselves.

AFTER THE ACCIDENT.

It was some time before the awful nature of the disaster was realized by those on the spot, but the spectacle of dead men being carried out and laid down at the side of the railway line soon dispelled it. Then those who at first only vaguely conjectured the extent of the catastrophe. Meanwhile the appeal for assistance was despatched to Thirsk and to the company's head-quarters at York. With all reasonable speed a break-down gang was upon the spot, and doctors from Northallerton, York, and Thirsk arrived on their way to the Manor House siding. The first to arrive were Drs. Hartley, Ferguson, and Longford, from Thirsk, and they were followed by Drs. Anderson, Tempest, and Gealin, from York, Drs. Lumley and Hutchinson, from Northallerton, as well as Drs. Dryden, Buchannan, and Ross. The break-down gang were at work by about half-past five o'clock. A message was also sent to the York Fire Brigade, and a full complement of No. 1 Company, under Assistant-Superintendent H. Carlisle, came along. The wreck was blazing furiously when the firemen arrived with the steamer arrived, sending up flames and huge volumes of smoke into the morning air. A supply of water was the first difficulty, but that was met by the discovery of a little beck about three hundred yards from the spot. By digging a hole in the bed of the stream a sufficient depth of water for suction purposes was obtained, and in a short time jets of water were blazing on the flames. Superintendent Carr afterwards arrived. In three-quarters of an hour the fire was prevented from spreading, and the firemen ceased to play upon it. The wreck, however, was still smoking, and blazing in parts during most of the day, until the break-down gang had succeeded in taking the smashed metal and the woodwork apart and removing it from the line. A number of prominent railway officials were also early on the spot, among them present being Sir T. Lowthian Bell and Mr. Henry Tennant, directors; Mr. Gibb, general superintendent; Mr. John Walker, superintendent of the line; Mr. Woodall, locomotive superintendent; Mr. Steele, outdoor assistant; Mr. Jesper, general superintendent; Mr. Wilson, traffic superintendent, Leeds; and Mr. Harper, station-master at York. The party was afterwards joined by Sir Frederick Milner, M.P., member of the division. For nearly two hours the passengers whose journey had been so rudely broken, were kept at the Manor House cabin; but some walked on to Thirsk and came up by which they were enabled to proceed to their destinations. Another of the marvels by which this disaster will be remembered is the small number of people who were seriously injured. Those who had to be immediately taken care of, and who were unable to continue their journey, numbered only two, the foreman of the express train, named Heads, and a Mr. Buchanan, who were taken to the Thirsk Hospital.

DETAILS OF THE INCIDENTS.

One of the most interesting incidents of the eventful morning was the rescue of a little girl called Lottie Hamilton. For a long time her screams were heard before she could be extricated, and as she was it evident that she was badly bruised, but she was suffering frightful agony from contact with the flames. She was tenderly carried from the Pullman car, but on the way she expired. A pathetic souvenir of the poor girl's fate was afterwards taken from the wreck. This was her doll, with the clothes of the Highlander. Its head was melted off, and the dress and body, like those of its unfortunate little mistress, were burnt. The dead were taken to Thirsk station, and laid out in the waiting-room on the upper platform. The doctors describe the demeanour of those of the passengers who escaped as perfectly calm and reasonable, there being no noticeable case of hysteria, but, on the contrary, an exceedingly cheerful disposition under the fate contrasted so favourably with those of some other of their fellow-passengers. There gradually came in light some items of personal injury, and of pathos to the disaster. Some of the passengers were left setting out on far journeys, of which the ride from Edinburgh to London was but the first brief stage. For instance, little Lottie Hamilton was bound for Scotland, in charge of an aunt and uncle to join her parents. She survived her aunt and uncle, and the uncle's name figures among the list of the injured. Among the Dundee passengers there were half a dozen who were bound for Brazil; and one gentleman, an official of the Hong-Kong Bank, was to have left this country for China on Friday. Captain Duncan McLeod, of the Black Watch, who was killed, was about to sail for India. At this season of the year the Scotch express has generally a full complement of passengers, and when it started from Edinburgh there was a good average number. One of the passengers, Mr. Alexander McKenzie, of Edinburgh, underwent a very painful experience. He was on his way to London, where he had obtained a situation, and he was travelling with his young wife, with their belongings, all prepared to settle in the metropolis. He was accompanied, and had had to be attended to by Dr. Hartley in an adjoining cottage. The effects of his physical shock were greatly augmented by anxiety as to the fate of his wife. In the middle of the day Dr. Hartley carried to him the sorrowful information that his wife's remains were lying beneath the smashing mass of the engine. It was her body, which was, perhaps, the most shockingly mutilated of all the remains that were discovered.

THE WRECKED TRAIN.

The scene was one which all have, which deeply impressed those who witnessed it. The engine lay upside down, with tons of metal "debris" all around it. Strewn around the embankment lay the shattered carriage cushions, steel springs by the dozen, pieces of charred leather, splinters of ruined carriages, fragments of upholstery, portmanteaus, baskets, and hats. The splendid Pullman was an empty shell, its elegant fittings twisted and smashed, its windows smashed, and its panels broken. Among the carriage-debris, at least against the hedge was one of a third-class compartment with a dignified "Engaged" still pasted on the window, just where its occupants, now dead, saw it when they started on their journey. It is needless to describe the ghastly details of the discovery of the fragments of the last two bodies, whose scattered bones and roasted flesh came to sight as the work-men disentangled the wreck. Among the others there were four carriages, the van, and the engine, which were thrown on the line, and several tracks of the mineral train. The guard of the train, G. W. Petch, of Middlesbrough, who was discovered in the debris, was killed outright, and there were at least seven children. With the aid of a powerful steam crane the wreck was let by his torn member, and by half-past one o'clock the line was open for traffic on one set of rails. Passenger traffic between Thirsk and Northallerton, which had since the early morning been taken over the loop-line "via Melmerby," was then permissible on the main line. At 5.40 p.m. the whole line was clear, and the break-down gang ceased their arduous labours.

CAUSE OF THE DISASTER.

No doubt has been cast by the officials on the current statement that although the mineral train was stationary on the main line, it was, in fact, partly within the box at Manor House siding, gave no warning to the driver of the Scotch express that the line was not clear. Such a picture is, perhaps, the most serious lapse from the responsibilities of his position, there is nothing to excuse. Having was hardly in a condition to properly fulfil his duties. A Mr. Fenwick, who had lately been ailing, and he had cut up with it, and thereby saved much sleep. On the afternoon of the evening when he went on duty the child, which suffered acutely from fits, died, and as it had not been attended by a doctor, the preliminary inquiries for an inquest were made, which greatly upset Holmes, and possibly induced a fit of absent-mindedness. It is further stated that he asked to be relieved, and that the request was refused. This last rumour is not confirmed by the railway authorities, although the likelihood is that it does was such a refusal it was because there was no one to supply his place at a moment's notice.

The signalman has been suspended pending investigation.

INTERVIEW WITH THE NORTH BRITISH CHAIRMAN.

The Marquis of Tweeddale, chairman of the North British Railway Company, in an interview with a correspondent, stated that he was a passenger in the second portion of the express. He had engaged a berth in the Pullman sleeping-car, and among his fellow-travellers was the Marquis of Huntly, the Kyneoch, of Keith, a director of the Highland Railway, and Mr. Lumsden Stuart. Having had a meeting of the Eastern Telegraph Company yesterday, the Marquis of Tweeddale turned into his berth soon after the express left Edinburgh. He was conscious of having a good night's rest, and most of the passengers in the Pullman followed his example. The Marquis was awakened by a violent shock, followed by the noise of breaking glass and woodwork and the escape of steam. He at once realized that a collision had occurred, and concluded that the train was off the line. It was exactly ten minutes past four. The Pullman car was comparatively uninjured, and those in it were soon aroused. The Marquis hastened to the disaster until they had clambered out on to the rails and had seen the great heaps of the wreckage. They found that the express had collided with a goods train heavily freighted with iron, and that the latter was on the wrong side of the railway. The Marquis of Tweeddale declared that the man in charge of the signal-box was asleep at his post, but this, of course, has to be proved at the inquest and the inquiry, which will be held at Northallerton. As far as I know there was no ladies, except Miss McCulloch, amongst the killed."

THE ARRIVAL AT KING'S CROSS.

The arrival of the express at King's Cross was awaited by Lord Colville of Culross, the Marquis of Huntly, who was also in the wrecked carriage, Mr. Lumsden Stuart, who came from York, but left the train at Peterborough, having experienced no further ill-effects at present beyond shaking, and Mr. Sutherland. The Marquis of Tweeddale appeared to be somewhat upset, although he stated that he had received no injuries. He and his Lordship alighted from the special saloon in which he had travelled, he was shaken hands with by Lord Colville, who congratulated him on his escape from danger. The arrival of the train from York was watched by very a large number of persons, many of whom had come to meet friends and relatives. The approach of the train was notified by the report of a couple of fog-signals. As it emerged into the station a great rush forward by those on the platform; while the carriage windows were scanned with keen and eager glances. There were some pathetic scenes, relatives meeting each other, and embracing with natural fervour and thankfulness.

STATEMENT BY THE REV. J. S. FORSYTH.

THE SIGNALMAN'S PITIFUL STORY.

A representative of the Press waited on the Rev. J. S. Forsyth, of the Caledonian Asylum, Caledonian-road, London, and minister of the Scottish Church of the same place, at his residence, and obtained from the author of the disaster to the Scotch express, the ex. gentleman having been one of those who travelled in the ill-fated train. The statement made by Mr. Forsyth was as follows:—

"I was returning from Aberdeen, where I had gone for the purpose of placing two of my sons at college, and had taken a place in a corridor carriage. I had left Aberdeen at midnight, and the journey was to be a long one, and I was looking forward to three rather important services next Sunday, it being the Sacrament of Communion with my church. Everything proceeded very smoothly, and I was dozing in a corner of the carriage in the front of the corridor. The other occupants of it were a young friend of mine, Mr. John Lumsden Stuart, of Burgoyne-road, and a lady whom I did not know, with her two children. I was ensconced in one corner of the carriage my friend in the opposite corner, the lady and her children had accommodated themselves on the seat opposite, when they were sopping. The train was rushing along at the rate of sixty miles an hour, when there was a tremendous crash. The light in the apartment was instantaneously extinguished. Then there was a yell, a shriek, followed by a second enormous crash. The roof of our carriage was driven in, and a part of the side dislodged, while all the luggage in the racks, consisting of several portmanteaus, came tumbling upon our heads. The lady, who was reposing on the seat opposite when I was asleep, had fallen forward on me with so much violence that my shoulder was forced through the window, and unquestionably I should have sustained some severe injuries to my back and shoulders but for the fact of my wearing a thick overcoat, which I had put on because of the cold, and the coat that you see me wearing below that. Again, a deadly stillness succeeded the violent crash, and in the darkness of course no one may be more sorely imagined than described. Fortunately Mr. Stuart, who is a young, active fellow, had about him a candle and a match, and disclosed to us the sad sight of our first instinct was naturally as to how we were to get out. Our lady fellow-passenger was shrieking with fright, and I did my best to pacify her; but her fears were not allayed by the fully of an individual who, because he happened to be a Highlander, in the low, shouting, "There's another train coming along," which, of course, was an exceedingly absurd and unnecessary cry. My friend first kicked the carriage with his foot, but as that was not to use, I wrenched a large splinter of wood from the roof of our carriage, and with it I managed to a few blows on the door. The scene that presented itself to my gaze on looking first around, was simply indescribable. Scarcely a picture in the world would be comparable. The engine lay across a hedge; while upon the top of it, as if it had been piled up with a pitchfork, lay a crowd of frightful wreck—with both its ends completely knocked in, so that you could see straight through it, one of its sides being shaved in entirely. My own carriage remained upright, but tilted over, on forcing the door. I was helped out by a porter. Some ladies in the next compartment to ours were locked in, and had to be taken through a window, and it was simply a miracle that they were not all killed. In fact, looking back, I really cannot understand how anybody escaped alive at all. The compartment where we were sitting was the only safe one in the whole train. The lady who had spent last part of the train was wholly wrecked. One of the ladies I have spoken about had her head so badly cut that, although she wanted to come on to London, she had to be left behind at York. She was bleeding terribly about the head.

"A few minutes after the collision," continued Mr. Forsyth, "the carriage were on fire, and I don't know there is a remnant of them left save the ironwork. It was perfectly dark, and my young friend, Mr. Lumsden Stuart, kindled a fire, his example being followed by other of the passengers, who compiled as nearly as possible an equal number of ladies and gentlemen. The weather was cold, with a keen frost, and we suffered the greatest discomfort until the arrival of the relief train from Thirsk about two hours after the time of the collision. The Marquis of Tweeddale had taken off his boots before going to sleep, and when he awoke was unable to find them. He had to walk to Thirsk in his stocking feet along the line and across a corner of a great field, in order to reach the labourers' cottages, where he got his unfortunate fellow-travellers who were able to go thither found both refreshments as well as shelter. When another train had come up the wounded were conveyed on it on their journey. The Marquis of Huntly, however, slighted at Peterborough; and it is, therefore, feared that he may be dead and dying was one man who was in a dreadful state. He was fearfully cut about the head. He kept exclaiming, 'Oh, my head, my head!' and cried out, 'Don't let me die.' He was covered with blood, so much so that I could not make out his features, so whether he was young or old. Lord Tweeddale came up to where this man was lying, and while a porter lifted him up and his Lordship wiped the blood from his face, the foaming or whisky to his lips, I held, up a carriage-lamp, but the man could not swallow, and he died shortly after. The dead were all taken on to Thirsk, and laid out on the floor, covered with rugs, in the goods station, pending the

"With regard to the signalman," the rev. gentleman proceeded, "he was in great distress when I went to see him, straight, and apparently level course. The shock and the effects of the collision have already been despatched. Never in the history of the North-Eastern Railway Company, and seldom in that of any other English railway system, has a disaster so terrible occurred. There have been numerous disasters where the loss of life and the number of injured have been greater, but rarely has a splendidly equipped train been so completely wrecked as in the case of the Scotch mail yesterday morning. The van at the tail of the goods train was smashed to atoms, and the guard, Petch, who occupied it, was killed on the spot. The waggon in front of the van, laden with pig iron, was also shattered, and the destruction of this waggon was well-nigh the whole of the goods train. The engine of the express, on striking the tail of the "goods," left the rails, and was to be "trying" as it slide at right angles to the track, with the tender alongside. Next to the tender came the van in which the luggage was stowed. Up to Darlington Conductor Wimpress had travelled in that compartment, but there happened to be no trouble about his train until they had arrived, changed into the centre van, in order that he might perform the same duty with respect to the luggage van which he had done in the previous one. Fortunately in all probability have been killed. The vehicle next to the front van was shivered into splinters, and the whole of the dead were travelling in it. Then came the Pullman sleeping-car, followed by two cars of third-class passengers. I have been in the van in which Wimpress was riding, and following it came two composite and two third-class carriages, and then a van, containing live fish. The engine was without a buffer, and the tender and three carriages following it telescoped, and were completely ended. Nothing remained with the engine what might have been thought a complete barrier to the progress of the vehicles behind. Fortunately, however, the Pullman, having four wheels, sprang over the pile, and landed in a somewhat scattered condition on the other side. The two abandoned carriages, and the two composite cars following the Pullman, tumbled one over another until the pile was probably not less than fifteen or eighteen feet high.

It was this mass that took fire, no doubt owing to its proximity to the engine furnace. The train was therefore kindled by gas, and the conflagration was due to the engine fire, and not to an explosion of the gas. Had there been at once the means of extinguishing a fire, such a serious conflagration would have been averted. There was no fire engine to be had, however, nearer than York, and notwithstanding that one with an efficient brigade was promptly despatched by train from the railway company's works at that city, it did not arrive before the pile of wrecked carriages was completely enveloped in flames.

Andrew Brydon, shepherd at the Manor Farm, who occupies one of the cottages close to the line, states—At a quarter-past four I awoke by what I thought was some shunting going on on the line. Shortly afterwards the people living next door knocked me up, saying that the Scotch express was off the line. I went out to render what assistance I could. When I got to the scene of the disaster I saw that three or four of the carriages, lying one upon another, and forming an immense heap, were on fire. The fire was not so great then as it afterwards became, but it was still so that it prevented me going near the carriages. My neighbours and I saw that we could save a quantity of luggage in one of the vans, and we started getting this out as quickly as possible. Several of the injured were taken into Mrs. Johnson's cottage, next door to mine, and by-and-by several medical men arrived. All the passengers who were able to come into our cottages were made heartily welcome, and we gave them tea, and did what else we could for them under the distressing circumstances.

Mrs. J. Johnson, who lives next door to Mr. Brydon, says—I heard the crash of the collision. The noise awoke me, and I said to my husband, "What-ever is that?" He left the house and falling out, he replied, "I heard something; but it will very likely be the bumping of some trains shunting." He got out of bed, lighted a candle, and went out, and "I see the signal cabin light," and, thinking that something was wrong, he put on his clothes and went to see what was the matter. The lamp had not been lighted more than five minutes when there was a loud knock at the door. The looking out we was informed, that a passenger train was off the line. We were asked if we would allow some of the passengers to come into our house, and my husband and I hurriedly dressed and came downstairs. I lighted a fire whilst my husband went out to see what assistance he could render. I could sit by the house, however, and although I was but lightly clad, I also went out to see if I could give any help. I assisted three or four out of one of the carriages, a boy about fifteen years of age, and, I think, three women. The boy was very badly injured, and before the accident occurred they had been talking about the Tay Bridge disaster. We brought a number of the passengers to our house, among them being some who were going out to America.

Alexander McKenzie, one of the injured passengers living at Mrs. J. Johnson's cottage, says—The crew of the women and children from fright or injury were unable to extricate themselves, and I saw no one by eyes when I think of it. I was asleep at the time, and when I realized that a collision had taken place, my sensations were very much those of a person who is about to be seriously maimed. My wife and I were travelling in a compartment of a carriage next to the front carriage, and I was lying on the top of the wife's sleeping car. I remember that I was wearing my glove the time; but when I was got out from among the "debris" I had only one of them, and my coat was much torn. My poor wife was killed, and it is marvellous how I escaped. We were right at the bottom of a pile which must have been 15ft. or 18ft. high; but I think my escape was due to a sort of the bumper which was in the middle of the pile. I suppose I fainted when I saw what had happened to my wife; and they were kind enough to remove me from the terrible spectacle which she presented. When they brought a light (that was about half-an-hour after the time the accident occurred), I looked at her and spoke to her, but she gave me no answer, and I saw that she had been killed. My clothes were saturated with water, and I was exposed to think came from the tender. I carried my money, excepting some 12s., which I had in my pocket, and I lost all the other contents, including £12, have, I am afraid, been consumed.

THE MARQUIS OF HUNTLY.

The Marquis of Huntly, who left Peterborough yesterday morning, after the Thirsk accident, very much shaken. His Lordship says that there were six passengers in the Pullman car in which he was travelling, and they were all more or less shaken and splinters. He does not know how they escaped, but he attributed it to the length of the car. He describes the scene as a terrible one, and he feared that the passengers being heartrending. He assisted in extricating two persons from the wreck, and he drove to the cause of the accident, his Lordship said he understood that the signalman was asleep.

LOOKING AFTER THE LUGGAGE AND MAILS.

Mr. R. A. Hodgson, lodging-house proprietor, of 37, Dundas-street, Edinburgh, stated